

Is Love Healthy?

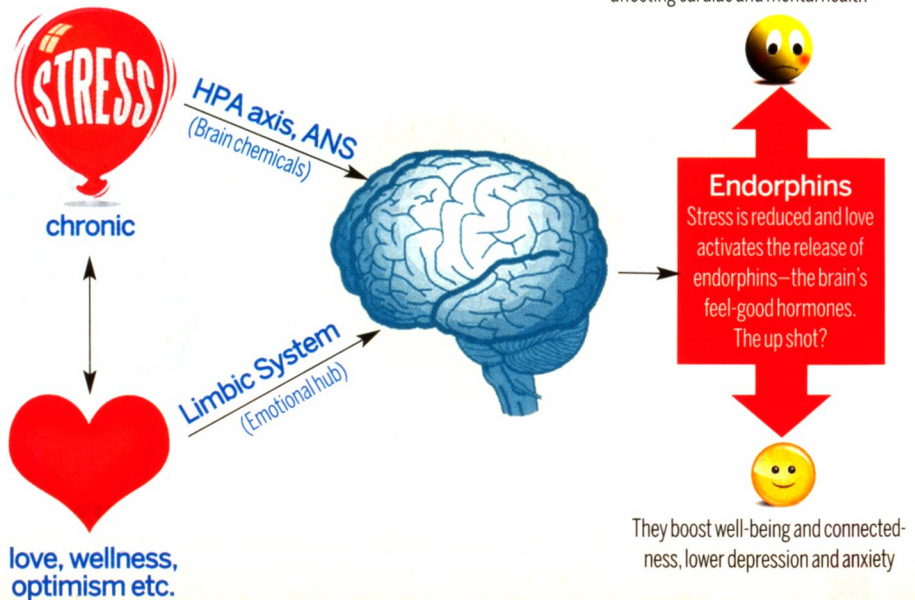
Respect love if you wish to be in good health is what scientists are saying now

CHEMICAL BONDING

Science has long neglected the mind-brain construct. But research on the neurobiological and physiological pathways underlying such 'healthy' phenomena as love, is now gaining recognition, especially with regard to stress-related diseases like cardiovascular ailments, neural and psychological disorders. Love, compassion and joy can help us battle disease and pain, they say. Well-being, of course, has been recognised as a powerful behavioural tool for supporting motivation and decision-making for quite some time. Love, say scientists, can be a resistance resource, facilitating trust and belief in the body's capacity to maintain health.

Stress and love act as counter players...

They make you tense and restless, adversely affecting cardiac and mental health



Love, Actually

A growing body of research indicates that people in loving relationships live longer. Love protects against death by warding off feelings of isolation and loneliness, and gives the immune system a boost too. Researchers found couples exhibiting positive emotions were less likely to get sick after exposure to infections (*Psychosomatic Medicine*), visited doctors less and had shorter average hospital stays.

Happy Marriage, Happy Heart

Happily married people have the best blood pressure, says a study in the *Annals of Behavioral Medicine*, while those unhappily married fare the worst. It's marital quality and not just being married that makes a difference, which shows that positive relationships can have similar benefits. Singles with a strong social network also did well in the study, though not as well as happily married participants.



That Thing Called Love

Functional MRI brain scans of strongly connected long-term couples show higher activation of dopamine—that part of the brain that keeps pain under control and produces the same kicks that you get after winning a lot of money. There's also less reaction in areas of the brain that produce anxiety and depression.

■ Compiled by **Damayanti Datta**